ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Academic Writing and Referencing: Say It Clearly, Cite It Properly

Structure, argument and citations for assignments that would otherwise lose marks

STUDY SKILLS

Study Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Marks are lost for the same reasons every semester: no clear argument, weak structure, quotation without citation and padding. This pack covers essay structure, paragraph logic, APA-style citation, paraphrasing and proofreading.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Plan and structure an academic essay with a clear thesis.
- Write paragraphs that make one point and support it with evidence.
- Cite sources correctly in APA style and paraphrase without plagiarising.
- Proofread for clarity, grammar and consistency.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Structure before style

An academic assignment answers a question with a reasoned argument.

- Introduction: context, the question, your thesis and the route of the essay.
- Body: one point per paragraph, each supported by evidence and explanation.
- Conclusion: restate the answer, not new arguments.
- Use headings when the assignment is long and permits them.
- Define key terms early, especially contested ones.
- Aim for clarity over impressive vocabulary.

> **The thesis test**
> Read your introduction alone. Can a stranger state your position? If not, your thesis is not yet doing its job.

Citation and plagiarism

Referencing is not decoration; it lets a reader verify your evidence and distinguishes your ideas from others'.

- In-text citation, APA style: (Author, Year) or Author (Year).
- Reference list entries: author, year, title, source and access details where required.
- Cite page numbers for direct quotations.
- Paraphrase by understanding, closing the source and writing in your own structure.
- Copying without citation is plagiarism, whether or not you intended it.
- Keep a working reference list while writing, not after.

Editing and proofreading

Editing is where average drafts become good assignments.

1. Put the draft aside for a few hours before editing.
2. Check that every paragraph has one clear point.
3. Read aloud to catch awkward or run-on sentences.
4. Verify every citation and reference entry.
5. Check formatting, font, spacing and word count.
6. Get one reader to explain your argument back to you.

> **Common killers**
> No clear thesis, unsupported claims, long quotations doing the thinking, and references that do not match in-text citations.

The essay is an argument with a shape

Academic writing exists to make and support a claim. The introduction states the question, the position and the route; body paragraphs each make one claim and support it; the conclusion states what has been established and what remains open. Everything else - background, definitions, context - serves that structure.

The most common weakness is a paragraph that reports rather than argues. If a paragraph could be replaced by a list of facts, it is not doing argumentative work. The fix is a topic sentence that makes a claim, followed by evidence, followed by a sentence explaining what the evidence shows.